

2, The Restoration-Bureaucratic System Was Fundamentally Incapable of Coping with the Military Realities of the Feudal Period

The second aspect: times change. The Chinese society of the **restoration-bureaucratic period** had undergone colossal changes compared to the Western Han period. Believing that the military pressure suffered by the late Chinese Empire would serve as a factor in maintaining the **restoration-bureaucratic system** is akin to "notching the boat to find the dropped sword" (刻舟求剑 / acting with absolute disregard for changing circumstances).

We can elaborate on this from the following three aspects.

First, when the Western Han faced the Xiongnu threat, Chinese society was still in the **classical period** (古典时期) where class transition was occurring. Although the wars unifying China under the Qin and the Chu-Han Contention had physically largely annihilated the clan-based aristocracy (氏族贵族) that had existed since the Three Dynasties (Xia, Shang, and Zhou), remnants of slavery remained exceedingly widespread. The newly emerging **feudal landlord class** (封建地主阶级) was still far from capable of standing at the center of the political stage as the backbone of society.

Therefore, for a classical empire like the Western Han, facing the Xiongnu's daily growing military threat, it indeed possessed a certain rationality to establish an unprecedentedly powerful bureaucratic system to integrate social resources and hurl them into the war (*provided, of course, it had the capability to achieve this*).

However, the situation facing the **restoration-bureaucratic states** was entirely different. From the Sui and Tang to the Ming and Qing, the **feudal landlord class** genuinely played the dominant role in China's economic production; thus, from an economic perspective, it was indeed already a class capable of exerting a greater societal function.

This brings us to a glaringly simple reality: there was no economic obstacle preventing China from entering a feudal class society. It was the **restoration-bureaucratic system** that, employing administrative power backed by military force, coercively prevented this from happening.

Therefore, when we consider whether the argument holds that external pressure during the restoration-bureaucratic period became the reason for the bureaucratic system's continuation, the very first thing we must ponder is this: **when the level of productive forces could already realize a feudal system, which is militarily superior—the feudal system or the restoration-bureaucratic system?**

I believe the answer to this question is resoundingly clear. Under a **feudal system** (封建制), **feudal lords** needed to bear military obligations and possessed an immensely urgent need to protect their own territories through armed force. Consequently, they bore no psychological burden when adopting new military technologies, and enthusiastically welcomed any military revolution capable of effectively enhancing their own combat power.

From the High Middle Ages to around the end of the Middle Ages, Europe experienced tremendous progress in the military domain. In terms of equipment (*whether the most traditional armor or the most advanced muskets and artillery*), military engineering (*such as fortress construction and ballistics*), tactics (*such as the Spanish tercio / 西班牙方阵*), and army organization (*professionalized armies*), Europe had established distinct advantages over other regions of the world. This provided

the martial guarantee for Europe's conquest of various parts of the globe following the Age of Discovery.

Although **feudalized** Japan, isolated in the East, could not remotely compare militarily to Europe at the time, once matchlock muskets (火枪) were introduced in the mid-16th century, it took merely half a century for firearms to become comprehensively popularized across the archipelago, profoundly influencing the military and politics of the late Sengoku period.

By the time Toyotomi Hideyoshi launched the invasion of Korea, the Japanese army of over a hundred thousand—despite conducting overseas operations beyond their borders—could still inflict massive casualties upon the Ming-Joseon allied forces (*reversing the order is too strange*), even killing high-ranking generals of both nations. Even though the Ming Empire ultimately repelled Japan, it suffered a catastrophic drain on its own vitality (元气大伤).

Volume 208 of the *History of Ming* (《明史》) explicitly states: "*Since the Japanese wreaked havoc in Korea for seven years, hundreds of thousands of troops were lost, and millions in stipends were squandered; the Middle Kingdom and its vassal state possessed no winning strategy until the Kampaku (Hideyoshi) died, whereupon the disaster finally ceased.*"

For a long time, the East Asian mainland possessed an overwhelming military superiority over the Japanese archipelago. Originally, given the geographical scale of population, the number, scope, and intensity of wars, as well as foreign exchanges, this was an inevitable reality. During the early Japanese Middle Ages (*Chūsei* / 中世) when the Yuan Dynasty attacked Kyushu, this superiority was still extremely glaring.

Thus, we can see that when the Japanese *Chūsei* drew to its close, the military gap between the Japanese archipelago and the East Asian mainland had drastically narrowed.

The second aspect: times change. The Chinese society of the **restoration-bureaucratic period** had undergone colossal changes compared to the Western Han period. Believing that the military pressure suffered by the late Chinese Empire would serve as a factor in maintaining the **restoration-bureaucratic system** is akin to "notching the boat to find the dropped sword" (刻舟求剑 / acting with absolute disregard for changing circumstances).

We can elaborate on this from the following three aspects.

First, when the Western Han faced the Xiongnu threat, Chinese society was still in the **classical period** (古典时期) where class transition was occurring. Although the wars unifying China under the Qin and the Chu-Han Contention had physically largely annihilated the clan-based aristocracy (氏族贵族) that had existed since the Three Dynasties (Xia, Shang, and Zhou), remnants of slavery remained exceedingly widespread. The newly emerging **feudal landlord class** (封建地主阶级) was still far from capable of standing at the center of the political stage as the backbone of society.

Therefore, for a classical empire like the Western Han, facing the Xiongnu's daily growing military threat, it indeed possessed a certain rationality to establish an unprecedentedly powerful bureaucratic system to integrate social resources and hurl them into the war (*provided, of course, it had the capability to achieve this*).

However, the situation facing the **restoration-bureaucratic states** was entirely different. From the Sui and Tang to the Ming and Qing, the **feudal landlord class** genuinely played the dominant role

in China's economic production; thus, from an economic perspective, it was indeed already a class capable of exerting a greater societal function.

This brings us to a glaringly simple reality: there was no economic obstacle preventing China from entering a feudal class society. It was the **restoration-bureaucratic system** that, employing administrative power backed by military force, coercively prevented this from happening.

Therefore, when we consider whether the argument holds that external pressure during the restoration-bureaucratic period became the reason for the bureaucratic system's continuation, the very first thing we must ponder is this: **when the level of productive forces could already realize a feudal system, which is militarily superior—the feudal system or the restoration-bureaucratic system?**

I believe the answer to this question is resoundingly clear. Under a **feudal system** (封建制), **feudal lords** needed to bear military obligations and possessed an immensely urgent need to protect their own territories through armed force. Consequently, they bore no psychological burden when adopting new military technologies, and enthusiastically welcomed any military revolution capable of effectively enhancing their own combat power.

From the High Middle Ages to around the end of the Middle Ages, Europe experienced tremendous progress in the military domain. In terms of equipment (*whether the most traditional armor or the most advanced muskets and artillery*), military engineering (*such as fortress construction and ballistics*), tactics (*such as the Spanish tercio / 西班牙方阵*), and army organization (*professionalized armies*), Europe had established distinct advantages over other regions of the world. This provided the martial guarantee for Europe's conquest of various parts of the globe following the Age of Discovery.

Although **feudalized** Japan, isolated in the East, could not remotely compare militarily to Europe at the time, once matchlock muskets (火枪) were introduced in the mid-16th century, it took merely half a century for firearms to become comprehensively popularized across the archipelago, profoundly influencing the military and politics of the late Sengoku period.

By the time Toyotomi Hideyoshi launched the invasion of Korea, the Japanese army of over a hundred thousand—despite conducting overseas operations beyond their borders—could still inflict massive casualties upon the Ming-Joseon allied forces (*reversing the order is too strange*), even killing high-ranking generals of both nations. Even though the Ming Empire ultimately repelled Japan, it suffered a catastrophic drain on its own vitality (元气大伤).

Volume 208 of the *History of Ming* (《明史》) explicitly states: "*Since the Japanese wreaked havoc in Korea for seven years, hundreds of thousands of troops were lost, and millions in stipends were squandered; the Middle Kingdom and its vassal state possessed no winning strategy until the Kampaku (Hideyoshi) died, whereupon the disaster finally ceased.*"(自倭乱朝鲜七载, 丧师数十万, 糜饷数百万, 中朝与属国迄无胜算, 至关白死而祸始息。)

For a long time, the East Asian mainland possessed an overwhelming military superiority over the Japanese archipelago. Originally, given the geographical scale of population, the number, scope, and intensity of wars, as well as foreign exchanges, this was an inevitable reality. During the early Japanese Middle Ages (*Chūsei* / 中世) when the Yuan Dynasty attacked Kyushu, this superiority was still extremely glaring.

Thus, we can see that when the Japanese *Chūsei* drew to its close, the military gap between the Japanese archipelago and the East Asian mainland had drastically narrowed.

In reality, in a **restoration-bureaucratic state**, the generals commanding wars are, first and foremost, officials. In some cases, they are not even military generals but civil bureaucrats, or they are forced to endure civil bureaucrats or eunuchs serving as army supervisors (太监监军).

Under these circumstances, for the generals themselves, scheming and jockeying for position (钻营) within the bureaucratic system is obviously far more beneficial than contemplating how to seriously fight a war. Moreover, within China's political environment, achieving military merit not only fails to bring any tangible benefits but easily turns one into a target for public attack and arouses the emperor's suspicion.

Therefore, we can see that even within China, the contrast between the two systems remains glaringly conspicuous.

During the bureaucratic restoration phase, the Song Dynasty, as the first mature restoration-bureaucratic empire, invariably had "military debility" (军事孱弱) as one of its primary images. The Ming Empire's national defense policy was equally exceedingly passive; merely half a century after its founding, its territories began to gradually shrink.

Conversely, the armies that were genuinely renowned for their martial prowess and practically accomplished the enterprise of expanding the frontiers all possessed distinct **feudal characteristics** (封建特征), or even inherently belonged to **military aristocracy** (军事贵族) conglomerates.

Examples include: the *Fubing* (府兵 / militia system) from the Western Wei to the Tang Dynasty, composed of rich peasants bringing their own weapons (*especially during the Western Wei, when the Fubing were entirely exempt from the Zu-Yong-Diao taxes, rendering their feudal nature even stronger*); the armed forces of the frontier warlords (藩镇武装) from the mid-to-late Tang to the Five Dynasties; the armies of the Liao, Jin, and Mongol Empires; the *Weisuo* troops (卫所兵) commanded by the meritorious nobles in the early Ming Dynasty; and the Eight Banners army (八旗军) of the Later Jin and Qing Dynasties.

Consequently, a highly dramatic phenomenon in the late stage of the Chinese Empire was that the Tang Dynasty's own bureaucratization was actively destroying the foundation of the *Fubing* system, rendering its expansion naturally ephemeral (昙花一现). By the time the Tang Dynasty perished, the fundamental territories of the Chinese Empire were no larger than they had been at the very beginning of the Sui unification, and the frontiers everywhere presented a scene of total collapse.

Even though the Song and Ming—two dynasties established by the Han people—possessed "military aristocracies" endowed with the merit of assisting the founding emperor (从龙之功) at the very beginning, the despotic monarchs of the **bureaucratic state** were intensely vigilant against these aristocrats potentially dividing or weakening their power. In a very short time, employing both hard and soft tactics, the emperors would cause them to disappear or at least lose all political influence. Thus, when facing external military threats, the Song and Ming dynasties rapidly sank into a highly passive situation.

Paradoxically, once ethnic minorities invaded and ruled **Handi** (China Proper / 汉地), because the population of their own people was vastly smaller compared to the Han Chinese, and ethnic contradictions objectively existed, the minority monarchs were compelled to rely on the armed

forces of their own ethnic **military aristocracies** to counterbalance the Han Chinese. And this, astonishingly, became the *only* reliable force capable of territorial expansion during the late stage of the Chinese Empire!

The fact is, after the Western Han laid the foundation for China's territory, all parts of China's *de jure* territory today—except for the various regions of **Handi** within the Great Wall—were initially contributed by dynasties established by three ethnic minorities: the Jin, Yuan, and Qing. Even Yunnan and Guizhou, which were considered part of the "Eighteen Provinces of China Proper" (汉地十八省) by the Qing Dynasty, were originally conquered by Mongol military force.

In conclusion, whether viewed theoretically or factually, when the economic level is sufficient to support the stable existence of a **feudal system**, the feudal system's military performance is vastly superior to that of the **restoration-bureaucratic system**.

Second, the bureaucratic system itself had undergone a distinct transformation—a fact exceptionally prone to being overlooked by observers.

During Emperor Wu's era, although an overly premature bureaucratic system was formed, the Han Dynasty was, after all, still in the classical stage of class transition. The expansion of the bureaucracy itself was a normal phenomenon (*though it is apparent in hindsight that the Han Dynasty over-expanded significantly*).

It must be pointed out that because the Han bureaucratic system occupied a unique historical position, it initially even accelerated the process of the **feudal landlord class** (封建地主阶级) stepping onto the historical stage (*because the landlord class had gradually formed an economic advantage, and public/private schools as well as the official selection systems favored them in acquiring power and position within the bureaucracy*).

Consequently, the newly emerging landlord class threw themselves into state politics with immense enthusiasm. They believed a solid bond existed between themselves and the empire, and paid close attention to the wars against the empire's arch-enemies. Even the war itself aroused the fanaticism of the emerging landlord class.

The emperor, adhering to the principle of "starve anyone but the army, forget anything but rewarding military merit," repaid meritorious individuals with gold, land, and noble titles. War became a casino for the newly emerging landlord class to acquire political status.

The Han bureaucratic system demonstrated exceptional administrative efficiency and low **internal friction** (内耗). While the court extracted wealth from all sectors of society, it simultaneously made massive, effective technological investments. This led to a rapid elevation of Han's technological level, especially reflected in the military domain—epitomized by the comprehensive popularization of iron weapons—which further expanded China's military superiority over surrounding regions, in turn encouraging external expansion.

Based on the above reasons, the Han bureaucratic system transformed the entire empire into a highly efficient war machine possessed of terrifying power.

However, in the restoration-bureaucratic phase (复辟官僚阶段), all of the aforementioned reasons completely vanished.

In this period, the absolute primary objective of the bureaucracy itself was to continuously suppress the landlord class to prevent it from seizing power—a goal inherently contrary to the **economic base** (经济基础).

To maintain such a **superstructure** (上层建筑) that was utterly incompatible with the economic base, the entire political system was inevitably fraught with internal friction; indeed, **it had to consume itself internally**.

In fact, starting from the late Chinese Empire, for the emperors and the court bureaucrats, the empire's greatest imaginary enemy was never external, nor was it any neighboring hostile regime; **it was precisely the very people they ruled**—first the economically powerful landlord class, and then the destitute, restless commoners.

Plunging society into internal friction would certainly weaken the state's power, ultimately leading to national subjugation in the long run. But without this internal friction, their thrones would not be secure for a single day!

Compared to feudal states, what **restoration-bureaucratic states** lacked was not just military capability, but the fundamental attitude toward the grand affairs of state—military affairs.

Rather than fearing a general losing a battle, the emperor was far more terrified of a general winning a battle; rather than fearing the pillaging of barbarian regimes, the Son of Heaven and his myriad officials were far more terrified of the commoners rising up in rebellion.

If observers look back at the Song Dynasty's army and think for just a moment, they will realize that this massive armed force was not so much for defending against the Western Xia and Khitans, as it was for guarding against those "tattooed exiles and conscripts" (配军之贼) within their own ranks.

As with the soldiers, so with the generals. Since the state was the private property of a single family (一姓之私产), as long as a deal could be struck, no part of state sovereignty could not be sold; among the meritorious officials who established military achievements, none was exempt from execution. I believe the history of the Song, Ming, and Qing dynasties has completely and clearly demonstrated this point, rendering any further elaboration entirely unnecessary.

If anyone expects stellar military performance from a regime that views the maintenance of the despotic rulers' privileges as the overwhelmingly paramount "stability," a government that points its bayonets inward and aims its blades at its own people—that person is an absolute idiot.

Throughout the entire **restoration-bureaucratic period**, the Chinese Empire's massive, disorganized, poorly equipped, and combat-ineffective army was utterly a "colossus with feet of clay" (泥足巨人). There are countless examples of small numbers of elite, feudalized barbarian warriors shattering a massive army like a hot knife slicing through butter (像热刀切黄油一样).

Therefore, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** bears absolutely no comparability to the bureaucratic system when it was newly formed in the Han Dynasty. To assume that because the latter possessed stellar military performance, the former would too, is completely irrational.

We can peer into the military system of the **restoration-bureaucratic state** through a micro-historical event that occurred during the restoration-bureaucratic period: the "Jianzhou Mutiny" (建

州兵变), which took place between the first and second years of the Jianyan era (1127–1128 AD) under Emperor Gaozong of Song.

(The Jianzhou mutiny is relatively completely recorded in the "Chronological Record of the Reign Since Jianyan" / 《建炎以来系年要录》. The Jianzhou mentioned here was an administrative unit during the Tang and Song periods located in present-day northern Fujian Province, China, and is completely unrelated to the "Jianzhou" in Northeast China).

The brilliance of this case lies in the fact that, although its duration and scope were very limited, it perfectly encapsulated a series of appalling military performances by the Chinese Empire during the **restoration-bureaucratic period**.

First, the court defaulted on the troops' deserved remuneration. The restoration-bureaucratic society could obviously no longer implement universal conscription (义务兵役制) like the classical empire of the Han Dynasty. Yet, while implementing a mercenary system (募兵制), the court never forgot the cost-saving benefits of universal conscription. It existed in a hypocritical state of wanting it both ways, making the full payment of military stipends virtually a miracle.

Second, when facing local turmoil, the combat results of civil bureaucrats commanding troops were utterly disastrous. Suppressing a rebellion in a single prefecture actually required mobilizing the central imperial army. Moreover, both mutinies were ultimately subdued through the deception of offering amnesty (招安).

Third, even though less than two years had passed since the Jingkang Incident (靖康之变 / the catastrophic fall of the Northern Song), the court *never* forgot to scheme against its own people. After the first rebellion of the Jianzhou troops ended, the court attempted to use a "borrowed knife to kill" (借刀杀人) by mobilizing them northward to engage the Jin army in a suicidal battle, which directly provoked the second Jianzhou mutiny.

Fourth, immediately following both amnesties, the court broke its promises and summarily executed all the mutiny leaders. This fully demonstrates that under the **restoration-bureaucratic system**, the cost for the bureaucratic government to violate promises and agreements was virtually zero. Consequently, a highly tense and suspicious political atmosphere inevitably emerged.

Fifth, prior to the second Jianzhou mutiny, the ringleaders, including Ye Nong, slaughtered their own wives and children. Their purpose was to eliminate their own "weaknesses/leverage" (软肋), thereby reducing the court's means of coercing and controlling them.

Scanning all uprisings in history across the globe, it is almost impossible for people to find insurgents murdering their own wives and children first outside of China.

As long as one has lived in China for a considerable time, it becomes glaringly obvious that **using family members as "leverage" to threaten one's own people has, since ancient times, been a brilliant, hallmark tactic of the Chinese court to brutalize its populace.**

During the **restoration-bureaucratic period**, such tactics were, of course, relentlessly employed by the court against its own military. This differs drastically from feudal Europe and Japan.

In societies ruled by **feudal lords** as aristocrats, there ultimately existed widely recognized codes of conduct among the nobility. The immense cost of breaking covenants was something Chinese despots could not even imagine. Moreover, for a feudal lord, the peasant conscripts they levied were

indeed their subjects (领民); but were the wives and children of these peasant conscripts not *also* their subjects?

In regions bristling with feudal rulers, employing indiscriminate slaughter to terrorize the populace yielded virtually no benefits other than violently shaking the foundation of one's own rule.

The restored Chinese Empire had absolutely no need to consider this. **One of the bedrock foundations of its rule was the implementation of absolute terror, and the people were never once viewed as human beings by the imperial family and the bureaucracy.**

One only needs to observe the state of the restoration-bureaucratic state's military power depicted through a minor event like the Jianzhou Mutiny to naturally arrive at a definitive judgment regarding the true nature of military performance under such a political system.

Third, the military situation China itself faced had also undergone massive changes—a point even more easily overlooked than the previous one.

If we look at historical maps from around the beginning of the Common Era, perhaps the most overwhelming impression is how incredibly vast and empty the world still was. There were incredibly massive regions left uncolored—simply because they were too backward, lacked written records, and it was impossible to determine what regimes existed there. This was precisely the characteristic of the **classical period** (古典时期).

True, in the centuries preceding the formation of the classical empires, civilization had expanded significantly within the borders of these empires. However, compared to the still-vast wilderness, the civilized world occupied only a tiny fraction of the total area.

If we turn our gaze back to the Han Dynasty, a glaringly obvious fact is that the **Zhongyuan** heartland—centered around the middle and lower reaches of the Yellow River—already possessed a long agricultural history. During the zenith of the Western Han, over half of its 60 million population was concentrated there, and the empire's rule over this region had assumed a "surface-area" (面状) form.

Conversely, the Han Empire could not possibly maintain such a "surface-area" administrative management across its vastly larger frontier regions. Its rule there could only assume a "point-and-line" (点线状) form. (*The so-called "points" were administrative units like commanderies and counties, and the "lines" were vital roads crucial to the court that required military protection*).

It was merely that the points and lines were denser closer to the **Zhongyuan**; in extremely remote frontier regions like Gojoseon (朝鲜), Jiaozhou (交州), and Yunnan, the points and lines became exceedingly sparse.

Therefore, the borders between states presented the following state: increasingly sparse "point-and-line" governance structures extending from the heartlands of both sides toward the borderlands from different directions (*naturally, lines would intersect, as roads eventually connect*). Although the borders might appear incredibly long on a map, the actual points of contact between the two sides were far more limited.

Precisely because the potential points of contact were limited, for a classical state, dispatching a massive army to cross the border from a few limited contact points, uprooting the enemy's "governing points" one by one along their "governing lines," and then driving deep into the enemy's

"surface-area" governing core was indeed a highly efficient choice for defeating the enemy (*provided, of course, they could actually break through*).

Therefore, large-scale armed expeditions dispatched by classical states to subjugate peripheral countries or attack each other—just like the Han Dynasty's external conquests—were relatively common military phenomena during the **classical period**. (*This primarily refers to Rome confronting Parthia and Persia; however, it must be emphasized that the Xiongnu's military power was inherently no weaker than these classical empires, though I do not classify the Xiongnu as a classical empire, for reasons detailed in Sections 25 and 30 of Chapter 12*).

However, feudalization changed all of this.

The elevation of **productive forces** (生产力) and the establishment of **feudal relations of production** enabled the growing population to transform the point-and-line rule in civilization's border regions into surface-area rule through land reclamation.

For mutually hostile regimes, even if the borderlines of the classical period and those a millennium later were drawn identically on a map, they had become radically different in reality. The degree of intimate contact occurring in the latter was something the former could not even remotely compare to.

Actually, if one is relatively familiar with China's military history, it is easy to realize that such glaring changes occurred even within the Chinese interior. A highly fascinating example is this: if you observe the domestic wars from the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods to the Qin, Han, and Three Kingdoms periods, you will find that perilous mountain passes and vital river crossings occupied staggeringly important positions in contemporaneous military theory. Many of them were termed "strategic chokepoints contested by all military strategists" (兵家必争之地), to the extent that their gain or loss directly dictated the outcome of a war.

But looking at the most recent ten centuries, people will realize that Chinese military strategists obviously no longer attached such extreme importance to these "impregnable passes and great river crossings" (雄关大津) within the interior. Those strategic strongholds once deemed capable of "*one man holding the pass against ten thousand*" (一夫当关万夫莫开) have been proven by successive falls to be insufficient as impregnable bastions (金城汤池) to secure the state.

Instead, people began to increasingly value the significance of overarching geopolitical blocs (地缘板块) in military strategy.

A major reason for this shift was that land reclamation was continuously progressing even within China's interior. Certain locations, endowed with the most optimal natural conditions, were initially favored by people, forming vital thoroughfares. But as China's population pressure gradually mounted, other places originally deemed unsuitable for survival were sooner or later opened up as residential areas, naturally creating new possibilities for transit.

With border contacts becoming so intensely dense, the era of relying on one or two impregnable passes to secure a regional fiefdom was naturally gone forever.

If this was the case in the relatively early-developed interior of China, such changes could only be even more pronounced in the border regions.

The fact is, while China halted its **feudalization** process starting from the Northern and Southern Dynasties and pivoted toward bureaucratization, the historical progression of other parts of the world—including the regions surrounding China—proceeded normally, and most of the Eurasian continent successively entered the era of **feudalization**.

When **feudal regimes** or highly **feudalized** regimes also appeared on China's borders, for a **restoration-bureaucratic state**, tasking the imperial army with guarding incredibly long borderlines brimming with points of contact became excruciatingly costly and egregiously inefficient.

Conversely, the most efficient method was obviously to let the **feudal lords** (vassals) guard such borders. Local manpower, material, and financial resources integrated on the spot under the command of lords possessing an intense desire to defend their own territories would not only incur minimal friction but also ensure rapid reaction speeds.

We must emphasize that in regions where the **feudal system** was more typical, military border conflicts rarely manifested as the massive, head-on clashes characteristic of the classical period, where giant armies sought to swallow the enemy's main force whole to conquer vast swathes of territory in one stroke. In fact, in a **feudal society** like Europe, a lord would be better off hoping to birth a few more daughters to inherit the enemy's country through marriage, rather than relying on such methods to acquire territory.

Even in Chinese history, it is easy to notice that being gradually nibbled away (受到蚕食), or proactively abandoning territories because the skyrocketing costs of governance simply could not make ends meet (入不敷出)—rather than losing the capacity for war due to the continuous annihilation of armies—was exactly the situation the courts of the late Chinese Empire encountered on their borders for the vast majority of the time.

Take Korea as an example. When Silla (新罗) was just established, even present-day Pyongyang was not within its borders (*when Silla first expelled the Tang army, the boundary with the Tang Empire was essentially the Taedong River, and present-day Pyongyang is north of the Taedong River*). Yet today, the border between North Korea and China is already the Yalu River.

Did the Koreans expand so far north entirely by fighting pitched battles? Obviously not. For the vast majority of the time, this expansion was nothing more than gradual nibbling (蚕食)—moving the boundary marker forward by one meter today, and two meters tomorrow.

The gradual breaking away of the Southwest region from the Chinese Empire during China's **feudalization** period follows the exact same logic. This appears exceptionally bizarre if one looks at Tan Qixiang's *The Historical Atlas of China* (《中国历史地图集》).

It clearly belonged to Ningzhou (宁州) during the Liu Song of the Southern Dynasties; it was still there during the Liang Dynasty; still there during the Qi Dynasty; and during the Chen Dynasty, it somehow ended up within the territory of Northern Zhou. Then, in the Sui Dynasty maps, control was suddenly lost, only for a highly threatening Nanzhao (南诏) to suddenly pop up in the Tang Dynasty!

(The reality is that the court had long lost control. The position of Inspector of Ningzhou was merely an absentee title [遥领]; the local area was actually ruled by powerful local clans of various sizes, the strongest among them being the Cuan clan [爨氏]).

It is precisely this inexplicable breaking away that reflects the true nature of the challenge the empire encountered on its borders when **feudalization** emerged in China's frontier and surrounding regions.

It was no longer the massive, clamorous invasion of tens or hundreds of thousands of barbarian troops—the kind of event a generation might not encounter even once. Instead, it was incessant, pervasive, small-scale incursions and pillaging, coupled with chronic, unceasing localism and centrifugal forces (离心力).

For enemies with a significantly higher degree of **feudalization** than the empire, such harassment did not necessarily demand significant battle outcomes (*and many times, they were not even government actions*). Failing to succeed resulted in no real loss—after all, there was virtually no initial investment. But once they succeeded, they would settle, cultivate, and fortify the small patches of land they acquired.

The enemies knew full well that the commoners of the Chinese Empire could not deal with them using the same methods. Because the court controlled the Chinese commoners through the system of "registering households and unifying the populace" (编户齐民), **terrified that the commoners might spontaneously build grassroots organizations**. They loathed the idea of the commoners pursuing their own interests instead of acting according to the court's will, and deeply resented them fleeing abroad.

The vast majority of imperial officials would, naturally, choose to hush things up and maintain a false peace (息事宁人). Reporting such minuscule territorial losses would only jeopardize their own official careers.

Even if the imperial rulers knew the truth, they might not be willing to take any action. Because for a **bureaucratic state**, taking actions that might trigger unpredictable changes over trivial matters was perceived as far more dangerous than losing a tiny bit of territory! If the territory was recovered, they had to consider how to reward the meritorious officials; if it wasn't, the majesty of the Celestial Empire (天朝的威严) would be damaged. Therefore, pretending not to know was naturally the optimal strategy.

History has fully proven the failure of **restoration-bureaucratic states** in frontier governance. On the contrary, during the late stages of the empire, the regimes that were relatively successful in frontier governance were precisely those established by ethnic minorities with a relatively higher degree of **feudalization**.

If we look at the Ming Dynasty's "Nine Garrisons" (九边地区) facing Mongolia, you will find that before the Tumu Crisis (土木堡之变), the Ming army had suffered no major defeats, yet the borders were already shrinking inward. After the Tumu Crisis, they still did not suffer any catastrophic defeats, yet the borders continued to shrink inward, until they retreated entirely to the Great Wall—the border wall continuously perfected by the Ming Empire to isolate the interior from the exterior.

In other words, the Ming Dynasty's loss of control over the territories and depth beyond the Great Wall was not because they genuinely lost so many main forces that they had no combat-capable troops left and were forced to abandon it. Rather, **they were forced to retreat because they could not cope with the nibbling tactics of the Mongolian tribes!** And this outcome occurred despite the capital itself being located right next to the Great Wall!

In more distant places, such as Vietnam, the empire's failure could only be even swifter.

When Emperor Chengzu of Ming, Zhu Di (明成祖朱棣), invaded Vietnam, he was undoubtedly still harboring the mindset of the **classical period** while acting as an emperor in the 15th century. After Vietnam had also undergone a considerably long process of **feudalization**, the Red River Delta was no longer a place that could be firmly grasped simply by controlling a few vital transportation routes and central metropolis.

The circulating officials (*Liuguan* / 流官) of the empire had absolutely no interest in earnestly governing their jurisdictions. The cost and probability of genuinely producing administrative achievements in such remote frontiers, gaining the court's approval, and subsequently earning a promotion could not possibly compare to the strategy of fabricating "auspicious omens" (制造祥瑞), scraping the fat and marrow of the people (搜刮民脂民膏)—especially local specialty products—and bribing superiors and subordinates within the system.

As for organizing resistance when the Vietnamese rebel forces approached, that was even more impossible. Aside from the Ming garrison troops, would the local commoners ever support them?

If we hypothesize that the Ming Dynasty were a **feudal regime**, after the Ming army conquered Vietnam, had they subinfeudated (转封) a batch of Chinese **feudal lords** into Vietnam while retaining the Vietnamese **feudal lords** who supported the Ming, thereby maintaining a state of local autonomy—then even if Lê Lợi (黎利) had struggled in Lam Sơn for over a decade, it would have been exceedingly difficult for him to achieve anything of consequence.

A world-renowned example of the **restoration-bureaucratic system's** complete impotence in the face of such increasingly **feudalized** border threats is the so-called "Wokou" (Japanese pirates / 倭寇) issue during the Yuan and Ming periods.

The Wokou, operating as pirates along the coast of the East Asian mainland, initially had Japanese *Ronin* (浪人) at their core. Later, they even evolved into multi-ethnic pirate syndicates, with ethnic Japanese constituting only a small fraction.

Yet, it was exactly such a disunited, highly irregular armed conglomerate that astonishingly managed to run rampant along the Chinese coast for nearly three centuries, reducing the Ming Empire's *Haijin* (sea ban / 海禁) to a virtual laughingstock! The imperial army was utterly helpless for a prolonged period; there was even the bizarre incident where a mere few dozen Wokou managed to rampage all the way to the city walls of Nanjing!

For the Ming court to genuinely reverse this embarrassing situation in combating the Wokou, it ultimately had to rely on armies independently organized and trained by individual generals (*which inherently possessed strong characteristics of feudalized private militias*).

However, the true decline of the Wokou was less attributable to any genuine combat achievements of the Ming army, and far more a result of the Longqing Emperor lifting the sea ban (隆庆开海) and the Oda-Toyotomi regime (织丰政权) unifying Japan.

The above facts demonstrate that even setting aside the gross inefficiency of the **restoration-bureaucratic state's** military system and the abysmal combat effectiveness of its army, its very organizational form alone was already starkly maladapted to the border situations of the

feudalization period. This, again, falls massively short compared to the feudal military systems that should have developed according to the normal course of history.

In summary, there is absolutely no reason to believe that just because the **bureaucratic system** during the Han Dynasty forged a massive and formidable army capable of countering military threats, the Chinese Empire during the **restoration-bureaucratic period** could achieve the same.

Countless facts prove that the military performance of **restoration-bureaucratic states** cannot remotely compare to what a China normally embarking upon the path of **feudalization** would have achieved.

2，复辟官僚体制根本难以应对封建时期的战争形势

第二个方面，此一时彼一时，官僚复辟时期的中国社会和西汉时期已经产生了巨大变化，认为中华帝国后期所受到的军事压力会成为维持复辟官僚制度的因素属于刻舟求剑。我们可以从以下三个方面进行分别说明。

第一，当西汉面临匈奴威胁的时候，中国社会尚且处于阶级发生交替的古典时期，尽管秦统一中国的战争和楚汉战争已经在物理上基本消灭了三代（夏商周）以来存在的氏族贵族，但奴隶制残余仍然十分广泛，刚刚崭露头角的封建地主阶级还远无法作为社会的中坚力量站在政治舞台中央。因此对于西汉这样的古典帝国而言，面对匈奴人日复一日变强的军事威胁通过建立空前强大的官僚体制来整合社会资源将其投入战争中去的确具有一定合理性（当然前提是有本事做到）。而复辟官僚国家所面临的情况完全不同，从隋唐到明清，封建地主阶级确实在中国的经济生产中具有主导作用，因此从经济上看它确实已经是一个有能力发挥更大社会作用的阶级。所以这就意味着一个非常简单的问题，中国不存在进入一个封建阶级社会的经济阻碍，使复辟官僚体制采取行政力量并以武力为后盾强行阻止了这一点。那么如果我们如果考虑在官僚复辟时期的外部压力会成为官僚制度持续的原因这个论点是否成立的时候，首先就应该思考当生产力水平已经可以实现封建体制的情况下，封建体制跟复辟官僚体制在军事上讲哪个更为优越。

我认为这个问题的答案是很明显的，在封建制下封建领主需要作为军事义务的承担者，有十分迫切地通过武力保护自身领土的需求，因此他们在接纳新的军事技术时没有什么负担，欢迎一切能够有效增强己方武力的军事变革。欧洲从中世纪盛期到中世纪结束前后在军事领域经历了长足的进步，在装备（无论是最传统的甲冑还是最先进的火枪火炮）、军事工程学（比如要塞修建和弹道学）、战术（比如西班牙方阵）、军队组织（职业化军队）等各个方面都已经相对于世界其他地区建立起了明显优势，这为随后地理大发现以来，欧洲对世界各地的征服提供了武力保障。封建化的日本虽然在孤立东方，在军事上远无法与当年的欧洲相比，可一旦在16世纪中叶传入火枪，火器仅用了短短半个世纪就在列岛全面普及开来并且深刻影响了战国后期的军事和政治。等到丰臣秀吉发动侵朝战争的时候，十数万日军在境外跨海作战的情况下仍能给予朝明联军（倒过来太怪）重大杀伤甚至击毙两国高级将领，明帝国即使击退了日本自己也元气大伤。《明史》卷208中明言：自倭乱朝鲜七载，丧师数十万，糜饷数百万，中朝与属国迄无胜算，至关白死而祸始息。长久以来东亚大陆对于日本列岛一直存在压倒性的军事优势，原本从人口地理规模，战争的数目、范围和烈度还有对外交流方面这都是必然发生的事情。在日本中世早期元朝进攻九州岛时这种优势依然极为明显，于是我们可以看到，当日本人的中世走到尾声时，日本列岛和东亚大陆的军事差距已经大大缩小了。

实际上，在官僚复辟国家指挥战争的将领首先是官员，在某些情况下，甚至不是武将而是文官，要么还要被文官或者太监监军。这种情况下对于将领本人而言，在官僚体制内进行钻营显然要比思考怎么认真作战有益得多，甚至于在中国的政治环境下，立下军功非但无法给自己带来什么好处，反而容易成为众矢之的并遭到皇帝的怀疑。因此可以看到在中国境内两种体制对比依旧十分显眼，在官僚复辟阶段，宋朝作为第一个成熟的复辟官僚帝国历来以军事孱弱为其主要形象之一，明帝国的国防政策同样极其消极，开国半世纪之后领土就开始逐渐收缩了。而真正以能征善战闻名并且在事实上立下开疆拓土事业的军队恰恰都具有明显的封建化特征，甚至本身就属于军事贵族集团，例如西魏至唐富农组成的自备武器

的府兵（特别是西魏时期完全免去租庸调的府兵，封建性质更强），唐中后期至五代的藩镇武装，辽、金及蒙古帝国军队，明初勋贵统帅的卫所兵还有后金-清朝的八旗军。

因此中华帝国后期一个戏剧性的现象是，唐代自身的官僚化就在摧毁府兵制的根基，其扩张自然沦为昙花一现，等到唐朝灭亡时，中华帝国的基本盘比隋统一之初只小不大，边疆四处都呈现出崩溃的局面。宋明两个汉人建立的王朝即使在开国之初存在有从龙之功的“军事贵族”，但官僚国家的专制君主对于他们可能分割削弱自己的权力极为警惕，在很短的时间内就会用软硬手段使其消失或至少失去政治影响力，因此宋明两朝在面对外部军事威胁时很快就陷入了较为被动的局面。反倒是少数民族一旦入主汉地，因为本族百姓的数量相对于汉族而言少得多，民族矛盾客观存在，因此少数民族君主还不得不以本族的军事贵族武装来对汉人进行制衡，而这恰恰成为中华帝国后期进行领土扩张仅有的可靠力量。事实就是在西汉形成中国的版图的基础之后，今天中国法理领土中除长城以内汉地各地外其他部分最初都来自金、元、清三个少数民族所建王朝的贡献，即使是到清朝被视为汉地十八省的云南和贵州也是被蒙古武力征服的。综上所述，无论是从理论上还是从事实上看，当经济水平足以支持封建制度稳定存在时，封建制度在军事表现上要优于复辟官僚制度。

第二，官僚制度本身已经发生了明显变化，这是尤其容易被观察者所忽视的。在汉武帝时期虽然形成了过于早熟的官僚制度，但是毕竟汉代还处于阶级交替的古典阶段，官僚制度膨胀本身属于正常现象（虽然日后可以看到汉朝明显膨胀过头了）。必须指出的是，汉代的官僚制度因为其所处的历史方位具有这样的特殊性，它在一开始甚至加速了封建地主阶级登上历史舞台的进程（因为地主阶级已经逐渐形成了经济优势，官私学校和选官制度有利于他们在官僚体制内获得权位），因此新兴的地主阶级也怀着极大的热情投入国家政治中去，他们认为自己和帝国之间存在牢固的纽带，十分关注帝国与宿敌之间的战争。甚至战争本身也在唤起新兴地主阶级的狂热，皇帝本着饿了谁也不能饿军队，忘了什么也不能忘赏赐战功的原则，用黄金、土地和爵位回报有功之士，战争变成了新兴地主阶级获得政治地位的赌场。汉代官僚制度展现出了卓越的行政效率和较低的内部损耗，朝廷虽然从社会全方位汲取财富，却又进行了大量有效的技术投资。这使得汉代科技水平得到了迅速提升，尤其反映在军事领域，以铁制武器的全面普及为代表，中国对周边地区的军事优势更加扩大，进而反过来鼓励了对外扩张。基于以上原因，汉代官僚体制使得整个帝国变成了一台高效并且具有恐怖力量的战争机器。

而在复辟官僚阶段，以上原因全都消失了。在这个时期官僚体制自身最首要的目标就是要持续性地打压地主阶级以免其夺取权力，而这原本就与经济基础是相悖的。为了维持这样一个与经济基础不相合的上层建筑，整个政治体制就必然充满了内耗，而且必须内耗。事实上，从中华帝国后期开始，对于皇帝和朝廷官僚而言帝国最大的假想敌从来都不在外部，从来也不是哪个周边的敌对政权而正是被他们统治的人民，首先是具有经济实力的地主阶级，然后是困顿不安的赤贫百姓。让社会陷入内耗固然会削弱国家的力量，从长期来看会导致亡国，可是如果没有这种内耗他们的宝座一天都坐不稳。复辟官僚国家比起封建国家，差的不只是军事能力，更是对于兵者这一国之大事的态度。比起将领打了败仗，皇帝更担心将领打了胜仗；比起蛮族政权的抄掠，天子百官更惧揭竿而起的百姓。如果观察者回顾一下宋朝的军队，稍微思考一下就会发现这支庞大的武装与其说是为了防御西夏契丹，不如说防的就是这些“配军之贼”。兵如此，将亦然，既然国家乃一姓之私产，那么只要一切谈妥，国家主权没有什么不能卖的；立下军功的勋臣，没有谁是不能杀的。我认为宋明清的历史已经完整清晰地展现了这一点，没有半点赘述的必要。一个把维护专制统治者特权这样的“稳定”视为压倒一切的政权，一个把刺刀指向国内，刀尖对准自己的人民的政府，谁要是指望它能有什么出色的军事表现那就是彻头彻尾的白痴。在整个复辟官僚时期，中华帝国那庞大，涣散，装备落后，战斗力低下的军队完完全全就是一个泥足巨人，少量精锐的封建化蛮族武士像热刀切黄油一样击垮一支大军的例子不知凡几。因此复辟官僚制度跟汉代刚刚形成时的官僚制度没有任何可比性，认为后者拥有出色的军事表现，则前者也会如此是全然没有道理的。

我们可以从中国复辟官僚时期发生的一个历史事件，即宋高宗建炎元年和建炎二年间发生的“建州兵变”来窥测复辟官僚国家的军事制度。建州兵变被比较完整地记载于《建炎以来系年要录》中，此处的建州是唐宋时期位于今天中国福建省北部的一个行政单位，与中国东北地区的“建州”并无关系。这个事件好就好在它虽然持续时间和波及范围很小，但是却包含了中华帝国在复辟官僚时期在军事上一系列令人难以评价的表现。第一，朝廷拖欠军队应得的报酬，明明复辟官僚社会已经不可能像汉代的古典帝国一样实施义务兵役制，但是朝廷在搞募兵制的同时从来没有忘了义务兵役制省钱的好处，处于一种什么好处都想要的状态，军饷能满额发放堪称奇迹。第二，在面对地方动乱时文官统兵战果惨不忍睹，一

州的叛乱居然需要调动中央军镇压，并且两次兵变都是通过招安来欺骗叛军降服。第三，明明离靖康之变才不到两年，朝廷却始终没有忘记算计自己人。在建州兵第一次叛乱结束后，朝廷试图通过调动他们北上与金军交战的办法借刀杀人，这导致了建州兵第二次叛乱。第四，朝廷在两次招安之后都立刻翻脸，全数诛杀了兵变领袖。这充分说明在复辟官僚体制下，官僚政府不遵守承诺和协议的成本是几近于无的，高度紧张和怀疑的政治氛围就必然会出现。第五，在建州兵第二次兵变之前，主谋叶浓等人互相杀死妻子儿女，其目的在于消除自己的“软肋”，减少朝廷拿捏自己的手段。遍览古今中外所有起义，人们几乎不可能在中国以外的地区看到起义者先杀害自己的妻子儿女这样的行为。只要一个人在中国生活比较久，那么他显然就会发现用亲人作为软肋威胁自己的人民自古以来都是中国朝廷残害中国人民的妙招。在官僚复辟时期，像这样的手段当然会被朝廷用来对付自己的军队，这与封建的欧洲和日本差异就很大了。在封建领主作为贵族统治的社会中，贵族之间毕竟存在广泛认可的行为准则，违背约定的代价之大绝不是中国的专制君主敢想象的。况且对于封建领主来说，自己征召的农兵是自己的领民不假，可是这些农兵的妻子和儿女们难道不也是自己的领民吗？在封建统治者林立的地区通过滥杀来对人民进行恐吓，除了动摇自己的统治很难有什么收益。复辟中华帝国就不需要考虑这一点，它统治的基石之一就是实行恐怖，而人民是从来不被皇族和官僚视为人的。人们只要注意到通过建州兵变这样一个小事件所描绘出的复辟官僚国家军事力量的状态，对于这样的政治体制下其军事表现究竟如何自然能够做出判断。

第三，中国本身面临的军事形势也发生了很大变化，这一点甚至比上一点更容易被忽视。如果我们看公元前后的历史地图，恐怕最大的一个感受就是世界竟然还那么空旷了吧，竟然有那么广大的地区甚至因为过于落后，缺乏记载，无法确定当地有什么政权而没有涂上颜色，而这就是古典时期的特征。诚然在古典帝国形成前的几个世纪中，文明在这些帝国的疆域内部都进行了很大程度的扩张，但是比起仍然广大的蛮荒世界，文明世界只占了很小一部分面积。如果我们把目光移回汉朝那么一个很明显的事实是，以黄河中下游流域为中心的中原腹地已经有了悠久的农业史，西汉鼎盛时期，6000万人口中的一大半都集中于此，帝国在这里的统治已经呈现面状。然而与之对应的另一方面是汉帝国在面积更为广大的边疆地区不可能维持这样面状的行政管理，其统治只能呈现点线状（所谓点就是郡县这样的行政单位，线就是对朝廷而言十分重要的需要武力保护的重要道路）只不过是离中原较近的地方点线比较密，在朝鲜、交州和云南这样极其遥远的边地点线已经变得极为稀疏。因此国家与国家之间的边境会呈现出这样一种状态：从双方腹地延伸出的日渐稀疏的统治点线状结构从不同方向延伸到边界（当然线和线会相交上，毕竟道路还是会相通的），虽然在地图上看边境可能非常漫长，然而双方实际发生接触的点就有限得多了。正是由于可能接触的点有限，所以对于古典国家而言出动大军从几个有限的接触点越过边境，沿着敌人的“统治线”拔除一个个“统治点”，然后长驱直入敌人面状的统治核心对于击败敌人这个目的而言确实是个高效的选择（当然，前提是真能打进去）。因此像汉代的对外征伐一样古典国家出动规模庞大的武装讨伐周边国家或者互相攻击（这主要就是说罗马和帕提亚、波斯，不过还是要强调的是匈奴的军事力量本身也不弱于这几个古典帝国，但是我不视匈奴为古典帝国，原因在第十二章第二十五和三十节）在古典时期是比较常见的军事现象。

但是封建化改变了这一切，生产力的提升和封建生产关系的确立使得日渐增长的人口通过土地开垦使文明边境地区的点线状统治开始向面状统治转变，对于相互敌对的政权来说，古典时期的边境线和一千年后的边境线哪怕在地图上画起来完全一样，在现实上已经变得截然不同，后者所发生的接触的密切程度是前者根本无法相提并论的。实际上如果一个人比较熟悉中国的军事史，那么他就很容易意识到即使是在中国内地也发生了这样明显的变化。一个非常有趣的例子是，如果你看春秋战国到秦汉三国时期的国内战争，那么你会发现在当时的军事理论中山岭间险峻的关隘和江河上重要的渡口占据了如此重要的位置，他们中有很多都可以称为“兵家必争之地”，以至于其得失直接关系到战争的胜负。但是等到最近十个世纪的时候，人们会意识到中国的军事家们对于内地的这些“雄关大津”明显没有那么重视了，那些曾经被视为一夫当关万夫莫开的要地，已经被一次又一次的陷落证明它不足以作为稳固国家的金城汤池。与之相反，人们开始越来越重视作为整体的地缘板块在军事战略中的意义。之所以发生这种变化，其中一个很大的原因就在于即使是中国内地土地开垦也在不断进行，一些地点因为其自然条件最为优越所以首先得到人们的青睐形成一个重要的通行要道，但是随着中国人口压力的逐渐增长，其他原本不适合生存的地方早晚也会被开辟成居住区，那么自然也就有了通行的可能。在边境接触变得如此密集的情况下，那种指望着一两个雄关就可以割据一时的年代自然是一去不复返了。

如果在中国开发较早的内地尚如此，那么这种变化在边境地区只能变得更为明显。事实就是，在中国从南北朝开始就终止了封建化进程转向官僚化的同时，世界其他地区同时也包括中国周边地区的历史进程一样在正常进行，欧亚大陆大部先后进入了封建化时代。当中国的边境也出现封建政权或者封建化程度较高的政权时，那么对于复辟官僚国家而言，让官军去负责守卫漫长的，充满接触的边境线就会变得成本极高而效率极低。相反，最为高效的手段显然是让同为封建领主诸侯去守备这样的边境，当地的人力，物力和财力都在具有保卫自己领土的强烈意愿的领主的指挥下就近整合，不但损耗很小而且反应速度也快。我们应该强调的是，在封建制度越典型的地区，边境的军事冲突已经很少表现为像古典时期一样的大军直接对碰试图鲸吞对方主力一次攻下大片领土的那种形式，事实上在欧洲那样的封建社会，领主指望靠这种方式获取领土，还不如指望多生几个女儿靠联姻继承敌人的国家。即使在中国的历史上我们也很容易注意到，受到蚕食或者因为统治成本过高入不敷出主动放弃而不是军队被连续歼灭从而丧失战争能力才是中华帝国后期朝廷大部分时间在边境所遇到的情况。

以朝鲜为例，新罗刚刚建立的时候连今天的平壤都不在境内（新罗刚刚驱逐唐军时与唐帝国基本以大同江为界，而现在的平壤在大同江以北），而今天北朝鲜与中国的边界却已经是鸭绿江。朝鲜人向北扩张了这么多，难道全是靠会战打的吗？显然不是，这种扩张大部分时间无非是今天界碑向前一米，明天向前两米这样的蚕食罢了。西南地区在中国封建化时期逐渐脱离中华帝国的统治也是同理，这一点如果看谭版《中国历史地图集》就会觉得尤为奇怪，明明南朝宋的时候属于宁州，南朝梁的时候也在，南朝齐的时候还在，陈朝的时候又跑到北周的疆域里，怎么隋朝地图里面突然就失去控制了，然后在唐代又冒出一个极具威胁的南诏出来（事实就是早就管不了了，宁州刺史属于遥领，当地实际由大小豪族统治，其中最强的为爨氏）。恰恰是这种莫名其妙的脱离反映了当封建化出现在中国的边疆和周边地区时帝国在边境真正遇到的是一种怎样的挑战，这不再是一代人遇不了一次的数万甚至十几万蛮兵声势浩大的入侵，而是无时不有、无孔不入的小规模的侵袭和劫掠以及长久不断的地方主义和离心力。对于比帝国封建化程度高得多的敌人而言，这种侵扰并不一定要求什么战果（很多时候就不是政府行为），不得手也没有什么损失，毕竟本来也没什么投入，而一旦得手就会在取得的小块土地去进行定居耕种并且设防。

敌人深知中华帝国的百姓没办法用同样的方式对付他们，因为朝廷用编户齐民的方式控制中国百姓，唯恐中国百姓自发建设基层组织，更厌恶他们追求自己的利益而不按朝廷的意愿行事，痛恨他们跑到国外。大部分帝国的官员当然会选择息事宁人，把这样微小的领土损失上报只会妨害自己的仕途。帝国的统治者即使知道的实情也未必愿意为此采取什么行动，因为对官僚国家而言，为了芝麻大点的事情就采取可能导致任何变化的行动比失去那么一点点领土更危险。收回来了还要考虑怎么奖赏有功之臣，万一没收回来则天朝的威严受损，于是装作不知道自然是上上之策。历史充分证明了复辟官僚国家在边疆治理上的失败，相反在帝国后期边疆治理相对成功的还是那几个封建化程度相对高一点的少数民族建立的政权。如果我们看明朝对蒙古的九边地区，那么你会发现在土木堡之变前明军根本没吃什么大败仗，但是边境就已经在往回缩了，在土木堡之变后也没有再吃什么大败仗，但是边境还继续在往回缩，直到退到明帝国一直在完善的长城这堵隔离内外的边墙为止。也就是说，明朝对长城以外领土和纵深控制的失去不是什么真的丧失了多少主力以至于没有可战之兵才不得不放弃，而是因为无法应对蒙古部落的蚕食而被迫回缩，就这还是首都在长城边上的结果。在更为遥远的地方比如越南，帝国的失败只能变得更加快速，当明成祖朱棣侵入越南时，他毫无疑问还怀着古典时期的思想去在15世纪当皇帝。越南也经历了相当长时间的封建化过程之后，红河平原已经不是控制几个交通要道和中心大城市就可以稳握掌中的了。帝国的流官没有任何兴趣去认真治理辖地，在如此遥远的边疆认真做出政绩然后得到朝廷肯定并升迁无论从成本还是可能性上都没办法与制造祥瑞并搜刮民脂民膏尤其是当地特产在体制内上下打点相提并论。至于在越南反抗军逼近的时候组织抵抗那就更不可能，除了明朝的驻军当地百姓能支持他们吗？

如果假设明朝是一个封建政权，当明军征服越南之后在越南转封进一批中国的封建领主并保留支持明朝的越南封建领主，维持当地自治的状态，那么黎利就是再在蓝山奋迹十余年也难有所作为。而复辟官僚体制面对这种日益封建化的边境威胁完全失能的一个举世闻名的例子就是元明时期的所谓倭寇问题。倭寇作为活跃在东亚大陆沿海的海盗最初以日本的浪人为核心，到后来甚至成为多民族海盗团伙了，日本人也只占一小部分。然而就是这样一个既不统一，也不是多么正规的武装集团，竟然能够横行中国沿海近三个世纪，让明帝国的海禁几乎沦为笑谈。官军长期以来束手无策，甚至发生过几十个倭寇跑到南京城下这样的奇事。明朝朝廷真正扭转与倭寇作战的尴尬局面最终还是要靠将领所自行组织训练的军队，

然而倭寇的真正衰退与其说是明军真的取得了什么战果，还不如说是隆庆开海和织丰政权统一日本的功劳。以上事实表明，即使抛开复辟官僚国家军事系统的低效和军队战斗力的低下不谈，单就其组织形式来说就已经显得很不适应封建化时期的边境形势，这又远远比不上按照正常历史进程应该发展出的封建军事制度了。

综上所述，没有半点理由认为汉朝时期的官僚制度缔造了一支庞大且强大的军队并且足以应对军事威胁则复辟官僚时期的中华帝国也能实现这一点，无数事实证明复辟官僚国家的军事表现远不可能与一个正常走上封建化道路的中国相比。